University English Teaching in the Artificial Intelligence Era

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Abstract

The rapid advancement of artificial intelligence (AI) technologies–such as natural language processing (NLP), machine learning (ML), and adaptive learning systems–has revolutionized global educational paradigms, exerting profound and multifaceted implications for university English teaching, especially in the context of English as a Foreign Language (EFL) environments. This paper systematically explores the transformative impact of AI on English language education, with a focused analysis of its practical applications across four core dimensions: personalized learning (tailored to students' proficiency levels and learning paces), intelligent assessment (automated and real-time evaluation of language skills), interactive instruction (immersive tools like virtual reality and AI chatbots), and cross-cultural communication (simulating authentic intercultural scenarios). By examining current classroom practices, existing implementation challenges, and emerging development trends, this study argues that AI-driven tools can significantly enhance teaching efficiency (e.g., reducing teachers' routine workload), foster sustained student engagement (via gamified elements and instant feed-back), and promote learner autonomy (enabling self-directed skill improvement). However, these benefits can only be fully realized if educators proactively adapt their pedagogical strategies to integrate AI in purposeful, education-centric ways. Critical issues must be addressed to maximize AI's value, including students' over-reliance on technology (which may hinder critical thinking and real-world communication

skills), ethical concerns (such as student data privacy and algorithmic bias), and the digital divide (disparities in access to AI tools among students in different regions or with disabilities). Ultimately, this study emphasizes that AI should be viewed as a complementary tool that empowers both educators and learners–supporting teaching innovation and personalized learning–rather than a replacement for human interaction, which remains essential for fostering emotional connection, pragmatic language use, and cultural awareness in language education.